



Both partners
ready



Simulation in
progress



Mediator
reviewing



Preparing your
results

Round 4 of conversation

eating stale pizza over a pile of spreadsheets trying to salvage a \$2.3 million dollar contract. I probably smelled like pepperoni and stress, not a bar.

The fact that you thought I was out drinking while you were waiting... that explains the wall of silence. But it's just not what happened. It was three hours of pure, frantic chaos. My phone wasn't even in my mind.

A

Okay. A work crisis.

But you have to understand, from where I was sitting, you came home at 9:47, you smelled like beer, and you offered a vague "work was crazy." You didn't mention Sarah or a specific contract.

And the phrase you just used... "My phone wasn't even in my mind." That's it. That's exactly how it feels. For months, it has felt like I am not in your mind at all. This isn't just about Saturday.

B

Okay, I... I can see how it looks from your side. And I can see why you feel that way.

The beer smell... we ordered pizza and my manager grabbed a six-pack for the team. I think I had one, just sitting at the conference table. It wasn't a bar, Alex. It wasn't me having fun. It was... fuel to keep going. The fact that you thought I was out somewhere, being careless... that really stings.

And you're right about what I said. "My phone wasn't even in my mind." That's a terrible way to put it. Of course *you* were in my mind. But the action, the physical act of picking up the phone... it just got lost in the panic of it all. It felt like if I took my eye off the ball for one second, everything would collapse.

A